Your decisions: batch 3 (16 items)

2026-11-09. From `runs/qa/2026-11-07-edits-ch00-ch16.json`. Each item gives the current line, the issue and my recommendation. Answer by ID, e.g. “Q001 most of it, Q005 yes”.

A. From last time (5)

Q001 · Prologue: which is true? “We’ve raised three kids together, both of us working full time the whole time, from diapers up through a house full of teenagers.” Ch14 says: “For about three years she’s been on sabbatical… to be a full-time mother.” Ch11 L37 says the same as the Prologue: “Three kids. Both of us working full time.” *My recommendation:* the Prologue becomes “both of us working full time for most of it”. Ch11 is about the decade she carried the income,

which ended before her sabbatical, so it can stay. Tell me if that's wrong.

Q005 · Ch1: "best husband" question, afterward or in the moment? Ch1 says to save the four-part review "for afterward, not mid-fight". Ch8 and Ch15 both ask the question in the moment and call it Chapter 1's question. Ch16 now makes those four questions the parts of arête. *My recommendation:* add to Ch1, after "In the moment itself, there's room for something smaller…": "Some nights the long question fits in one breath too: *Am I being the best husband I can be right now?* Ask it that way in the moment if it comes. Save the four checks for later."

Q006 · Ch4: "Anger isn't strength. It's the absence of it." The chapter just said the first flash of anger is involuntary. Read literally, this line calls feeling anger weakness. *My*

recommendation: “**Acting on** anger isn’t strength. It’s the absence of it.”

Q028 · Ch2: “That’s not loving her. That’s adding to her weight.” One desk says it repeats the line before it. The other says keep it. *My recommendation:* keep it. It’s your line, and it lands.

Q097 · Ch11: “I tolerate that because I want her to have real friends.” The proposed change is “I’m glad she has real friends…”. *My recommendation:* keep “tolerate”. The next paragraph is about when tolerating makes sense, so the word carries the point.

B. Your story: only you know (5)

Q115 · Ch16: one argument or two? Now: “In Chapter 1, my calm went cold and I said

nothing. Another time, my cold calm came out in words, said straight to my wife." Your interview reads as one argument: you sat quiet, and when she finished you said "I can't control you…". The draft splits it into two events. *My recommendation, if it was one:* "I told you in Chapter 1 how I'd go calm and quiet and wait for her upset to pass. What I didn't tell you is that early on, I once said the quiet part out loud." If it really was two events, change only "In Chapter 1, my calm went cold" to "In Chapter 1, I told you how my calm went cold".

Q116 · Ch16: "It should be a mindset, not something that you repeat out loud to her." A defensive reader can hear "keep it in your head", which is the Ch1 failure. In Round 4 you said it's about holding your own conduct to a standard; Round 11 cut that sentence. *My recommendation:* add after it:

“As a mindset, it’s a standard I hold my own conduct to.”

Q118 · Ch16: call back the Introduction? The Introduction says: “The river without the sun becomes detached. His calm comes from no longer being invested.” That is exactly Ch16’s story, and nothing calls it back. *My recommendation:* before “What fixed it was turning toward her.” add: “At the start of this book I wrote that the river without the sun becomes detached, that his calm comes from no longer being invested. That was me.”

Q049 · Ch11: the decade she carried the income “For about ten years, we lived mostly on my wife’s income…” The paragraph is about what you gave up; there’s no word of what her carrying it meant. *Needs one line in your words.* A starting point you can change: “I don’t think I thanked her enough for carrying us through that.”

Q112 · Ch14: the Avatar gesture and the hollow thanks Now: “At every meal, I thank the kids and I thank her. I think the thanks can land as hollow, like an ’I love you’ said with nothing behind it.” It’s unclear whether the fingertip and “I see you” are your answer to hollow thanks, or just one more ritual. *My recommendation, if that’s what you mean:* “A quick thanks can land hollow, like an ’I love you’ said with nothing behind it. The fingertip and ’I see you’ are how we try to mean it.”

C. Wording calls (4)

Q100 · Ch12: “Romance is trying to win favor with your wife.” One earlier review says it reads as a transaction. Another says it’s your chosen language. L51 now says “Trying to win her favor doesn’t mean expecting payment for it.” *My recommendation:* keep. It’s yours, and L51 now answers the worry.

Q122 · Ch16: dates against Ch12 "If you haven't done that, you haven't really thought about your investing strategy." Ch12 said "the date matters less than the thought". *My recommendation:* keep your sentence, and add before "So have a system.": "Chapter 12 said the date matters less than the thought behind it. The thought starts with knowing it's coming."

Q136 · Ch16: "That person is different from you, and you can't control them." This echoes the "I can't control you" line the chapter just called smug. One reader says that undercuts it; the other says the echo is deliberate. *My recommendation:* keep it if Q116 lands, because the new sentence settles what the line means. Otherwise use "and you don't get to decide for them."

Q138 · Ch16 last line: "Put the most into your marriage, because she is your

number one.” The outline asked for a closing line in the house image. The only proposal adds “home”, which would put the chapter back over its image cap. *My recommendation:* keep your line.

D. Sources (2)

Q040 · Ch7: Pillemer Now: “…interviewing people who’d been married more than four decades…” The Fact-Checker says Ch10 is right: thirty years or more. *My recommendation:* “There’s a researcher named Karl Pillemer who spent years asking more than seven hundred people who’d been married thirty years or more what actually worked.” Also add “in Germany” to the 7,000-couple study, as the earlier check asked.

Q055 · Ch12: an unsourced claim “Couples followed over the years don’t usually come apart because the fighting starts. They come

apart because the warmth stops… and the research only says they travel together." No study is named. *My recommendation:* state it as your observation: "In long marriages, the danger usually isn't that the fighting starts. It's that the warmth stops." Then "Partners who feel appreciated tend to be more appreciative back, though the research can't say which comes first."